HACKATHON

UAE

BEYOND IDEAS · INTO IMPACT

HACKARENA · READINESS PACK

HackArena Playbook 2026

Abu Dhabi | 26–28 Oct . Track 2: Youth Track — Rising Stars & Pioneers

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The full briefing: dates, journey, judging & awards

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Data Portals
Where to find real UAE government open data

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A free toolkit to research, design & prototype

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Your final gate before the Kickoff

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Track 2 at a Glance

The essentials of the Youth Track, in one page.

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PARTICIPANT GROUPS

Rising Stars (school) and Pioneers (university)

2–7

MEMBERS PER TEAM

Teams register together and are judged as a unit

3

HACKARENA DAYS

Preceded by a one-hour online Kickoff

5 + 3

MINUTES ON PITCH DAY

A 5-minute pitch followed by 3 minutes of questions

The HackArena journey

KICKOFF	DAY 1	DAY 2	DAY 3
Online orientation 16 Oct	**Understand & Explore** 26 Oct	**Build & Shape** 27 Oct	**Refine & Pitch** 28 Oct
OUTCOME Youth Track overview, the challenges, registration, team formation and challenge selection.	**OUTCOME** Clear problem, target user, solution concept and an initial plan for building.	**OUTCOME** A first simple prototype with mentor feedback, aligned to a Business Model Canvas.	**OUTCOME** Rehearsals, final submission by 12:00 pm, then pitching and judging.

How to use this playbook

COMPONENT	WHAT IT GIVES YOU	WHEN TO USE IT
01 Frequently Asked Questions	The full briefing: dates, journey, judging & awards	Read first, as soon as you receive the pack
02 Government Open Data Portals	Where to find real UAE government open data	While framing your problem and planning the build
03 AI Tools	A free toolkit to research, design & prototype	Throughout the three HackArena days
04 Readiness Checklist	Your final gate before the Kickoff	Complete every item before 26 Oct

START HERE

Read this playbook alongside the full **Challenge Profiles**, shared separately via drive. Your chosen challenge profile is the single most important input to a strong, well-scoped solution.

COMPONENT 01

01

Frequently Asked Questions

Your full briefing on the UAE Hackathon 2026 — Track 2 HackArena.

BEYOND IDEAS · INTO IMPACT

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KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Two groups compete: **Rising Stars** (school students) and **Pioneers** (university students).
- Teams of **2–7 members** work on a predefined challenge selected at registration.
- Three HackArena days: **Understand & Explore**, **Build & Shape**, **Refine & Pitch**.
- Submit on Day 3 by **12:00 pm**; each team pitches for **5 minutes** plus **3 minutes** of questions.
- The top ten teams in each group are awarded; promising teams continue into **LaunchPad**.

1.1 About

What is the UAE Hackathon?

The UAE Hackathon is the nation's largest competitive innovation program. It brings together entrepreneurs, researchers, government employees, and innovators to design solutions for real challenges facing UAE government entities, improving quality of life and the efficiency of public services. It is organized by the Telecommunications and Digital Government Regulatory Authority (TDRA).

Who is Track 2 for?

Track 2 is the **Youth Track** Hackathon. It covers two participant groups:

GROUP 1 · SCHOOL STUDENTS

Rising Stars

PARTICIPANTS

School students developing creative ideas to address the hackathon challenges.

FOCUS

Proposing innovative, challenge-aligned ideas that demonstrate potential community impact, creative applications of AI and emerging technologies, and effective use of available data. Solutions should be feasible at an appropriate level of development and presented through a clear, creative, and compelling pitch.

GROUP 2 · UNIVERSITY STUDENTS

Pioneers

PARTICIPANTS

University students developing innovative solutions to address the hackathon challenges.

FOCUS

Designing feasible, high-impact solutions that leverage open government data, AI, and emerging technologies to enhance digital government services. Solutions should demonstrate implementation potential, a clear 90-day execution plan, and opportunities for commercialization or integration into existing systems, supported by a compelling and well-structured pitch.

What is the overall aim?

The 2026 program has shifted the focus from idea generation to delivering implementable, high-impact solutions, powered by AI across the phases and supported by mentorship, workshops, and a post-hackathon route.

Do we choose our own problem?

No. Teams work within an existing, predefined challenge selected during registration, rather than formulating an entirely new problem statement. Your job is to understand that challenge deeply and design a strong solution for it.

1.2 Key Dates & Journey

What are the key dates?

EXHIBIT 1 **Key milestones**

MILESTONE	DATE
Online Orientation: HackArena Kickoff (online)	**16 Oct**
HackArena Day 1: Understand & Explore	**26 Oct**
HackArena Day 2: Build & Shape	**27 Oct**
HackArena Day 3: Refine & Pitch	**28 Oct**

PLAN AHEAD

> Day 3 is pitch day: teams rehearse in the morning, then pitch to the judging panels — **finish your building on Day 2.**

What happens before the event?

The first stage of preparation runs before the HackArena, so the event itself can focus on building. Two things prepare you:

- **The HackArena Playbook (this Readiness Pack):** Contains the UAE Hackathon overview, access to the full challenge profiles, an overview of the data platforms available, a readiness checklist, and this FAQ.
- **Online Orientation:** A one-hour online Kickoff on October 16th, and introducing the Youth Track, the challenges, how to register, form a team and select a challenge, and the three-day journey. The session recording is available here: link

How do the three HackArena days work?

EXHIBIT 2 **The three-day HackArena journey**

DAY	WHAT HAPPENS	BY THE END OF THE DAY
DAY 1 **Understand & Explore** 26 Oct	Design Thinking sessions on understanding users and defining the problem, then on generating ideas. Teams write a clear problem statement, compare solution options, select one, and plan the build. Mentors rotate between teams on two different slots.	A clear problem, target user, solution concept, and an initial plan for building.
DAY 2 **Build & Shape** 27 Oct	A session on prototyping and testing, then teams build a first simple prototype and get mentor feedback on it. A session on the Business Model Canvas follows, and teams build their own canvas and align it with the prototype. The prototype does not need to be technically complete — the goal is to make your idea visible, understandable, and testable.	Something you can demonstrate and a clear view of how your solution creates value.
DAY 3 **Refine & Pitch** 28 Oct	Team pitch rehearsals, then final pitching and judging in front of the panels, followed by the closing.	A final submission and a 5-minute pitch to the judging panel.

1.3 Getting Ready & Participating

How do I take part and get ready?

Review the HackArena Playbook carefully as soon as you receive it and complete the Readiness Checklist (see Component 04). Attend the online Kickoff on October 16th, 2026; if you cannot attend, kindly review the recording here: link

Can I participate as a team, and how large can it be?

The hackathon is team-based and collaborative. You form your team and agree roles as part of the registration steps, and teams are judged and supported as a unit. Teams require a minimum of **two (2)** members and a maximum of **seven (7)** members to register. A guided team formation session on Day 1 helps participants who still need a team to find one.

1.4 Support, Data & Resources

What support will I get?

Throughout the hackathon, participants will receive structured training, mentorship, and practical tools to guide them through the solution development methodology and prepare them to pitch their ideas effectively. Mentors will rotate between teams on Days 1 and 2, while additional technical sessions will be available through TDRA Academy.

What data can I use?

You are encouraged to build data-driven solutions using the UAE's open data platforms (see Component 02). Through co-creation with your challenge mentor, you are also encouraged to investigate the availability of relevant datasets, what each contains, its access type, and how to use it.

1.5 Submission & Judging

How and when do I submit?

Teams finalize and submit on Day 3 (28 Oct), with a hard close at **12:00 pm**. Make sure you know the submission requirements before the day.

How does judging run?

Judging takes place on Day 3. Each team gives a **5-minute pitch** followed by **3 minutes of questions**.

EXHIBIT 3 **Judging criteria — Rising Stars**

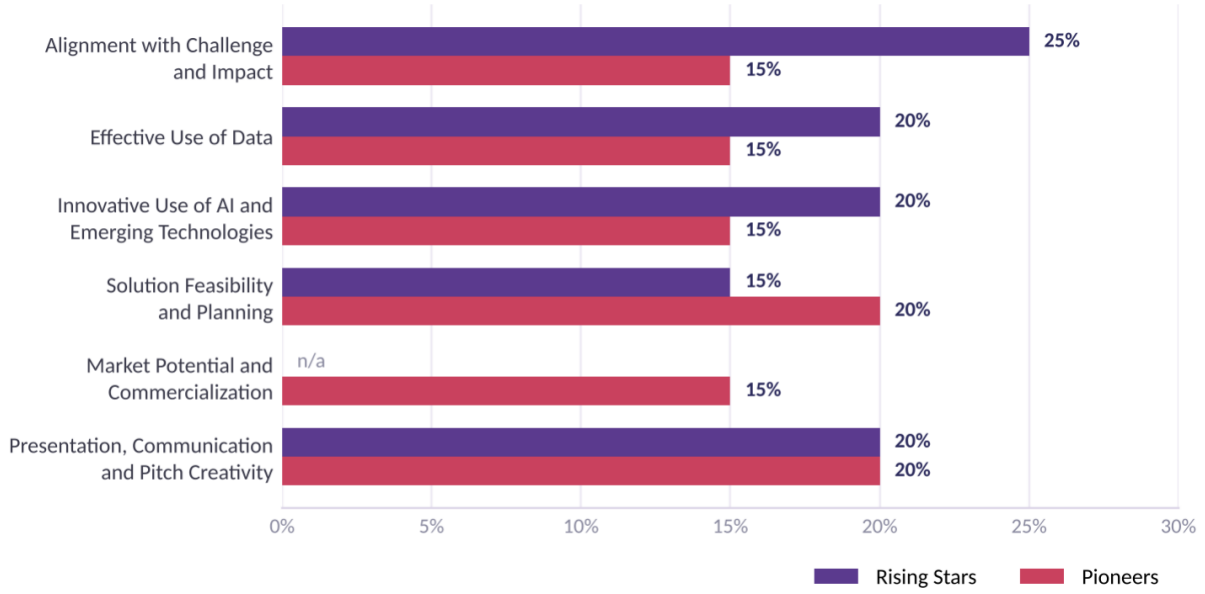
CRITERION	DEFINITION	WEIGHT
Alignment with Challenge and Impact	Evaluated on alignment with the nature of the presented challenge, the ability to create tangible impact addressing issues related to the core themes, and the contribution to enhancing the quality of digital government services provided to the community.	**25%**
Effective Use of Data	Evaluated on the effectiveness and sustainability of the use of open data provided by government entities. Priority is given to solutions that employ this data in an innovative and comprehensive manner.	**20%**
Innovative Use of AI and Emerging Technologies	Evaluated on the degree of innovation in utilizing AI and emerging technologies to address the presented challenges and deliver tangible added value.	**20%**
Solution Feasibility and Planning	Evaluated on ease of implementation in the actual work environment of the government entity, including a clear 90-day execution plan to test the product, with defined milestones and a realistic timeline.	**15%**
Presentation, Clarity of Communication and Creativity of the Pitch	Evaluated on the clarity and persuasiveness of the presentation in conveying the solution's value, applicability, and potential impact.	**20%**

EXHIBIT 4 **Judging criteria — Pioneers**

CRITERION	DEFINITION	WEIGHT
Alignment with Challenge and Impact	Evaluated on alignment with the nature of the presented challenge, the ability to create tangible impact addressing issues related to the core themes, and the contribution to enhancing the quality of digital government services provided to the community.	**15%**

CRITERION	DEFINITION	WEIGHT
Effective Use of Data	Evaluated on the effectiveness and sustainability of the use of open data provided by government entities. Priority is given to solutions that employ this data in an innovative and comprehensive manner.	**15%**
Innovative Use of AI and Emerging Technologies	Evaluated on the degree of innovation in utilizing AI and emerging technologies to address the presented challenges and deliver tangible added value.	**15%**
Solution Feasibility and Planning	Evaluated on ease of implementation in the actual work environment of the government entity, including a clear 90-day execution plan to test the product, with defined milestones and a realistic timeline.	**20%**
Market Potential and Commercialization	The potential for the solution to be commercially viable or adopted in the market — how likely it can be monetized or integrated into existing systems or services.	**15%**
Presentation, Clarity of Communication and Creativity of the Pitch	Evaluated on the clarity and persuasiveness of the presentation in conveying the solution's value, applicability, and potential impact.	**20%**

EXHIBIT 5 **Weighting comparison by group**



Note: Market Potential and Commercialization applies to Pioneers only.

1.6 After the Hackathon

What happens if my team wins or shows strong potential?

Promising teams move into the **LaunchPad** post-hackathon phase, where they receive further guidance to enhance their solutions, develop their pitching and communication skills, explore market potential and impact, and leverage AI-supported prototyping. Selected teams may also showcase their solutions at the **UAE Innovation Summit** in November 2026, with further development opportunities available through ecosystem partners. Winning teams are recognized based on the final evaluation of their solutions.

1.7 Awards & Recognition

What are the prizes?

Each group recognizes its top ten teams:

EXHIBIT 6 **Prize structure (AED)**

RANK	RISING STARS (AED)	PIONEERS (AED)
1st	10,000	20,000
2nd	8,000	15,000
3rd	5,000	10,000
4th – 10th	3,000 each	5,000 each

1.8 Quick Reference

KEY DATES

Kickoff 16 Oct · HackArena 26–28 Oct

SUBMISSION

Day 3 (28 Oct), 12:00 pm

COMPONENT 02

02

Government Open Data Portals

Where to find real government data for your challenge.

BEYOND IDEAS · INTO IMPACT

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KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Open data helps you understand your challenge and build **evidence-informed** solutions; effective use of data is assessed in judging.
- Assess each dataset's **source, coverage, currency, format and suitability**.
- Data availability varies — where data is missing, **state your assumptions** and the data you would need.
- **Start with Bayanat**, then use the emirate profiles to pick the right source.

Open government data can help teams better understand their selected challenge, identify patterns, and develop evidence-informed solutions. The portals below provide starting points for exploring publicly available UAE datasets. Where relevant, teams should assess the data's source, coverage, currency, format, and suitability for their proposed solution. Effective use of data is assessed under the judging criteria.

DATA AVAILABILITY

The availability of relevant data varies by challenge. Teams should not assume that all required datasets are publicly available or accessible through an API. Where data is unavailable, teams should explain the assumptions behind their proposed solution and identify what additional data would be needed.

2.1 Quick Index

EXHIBIT 7 **Official open data sources by level**

LEVEL	PORTAL	WEBSITE
Federal (UAE)	Bayanat — official UAE open data portal	bayanat.ae
Abu Dhabi	Abu Dhabi Open Data Platform	data.abudhabi
Dubai	Data.Dubai	data.dubai/en
Sharjah	Dept. of Statistics & Community Development (DSCD)	dscd.ae
Sharjah	Digital Sharjah (services + indicators)	ds.sharjah.ae
Ajman	Ajman Data	data.ajman.ae
Ras Al Khaimah	RAK Centre for Statistics & Studies	css.rak.ae
Fujairah	Fujairah Government Open Data	fujairah.ae
Umm Al Quwain	Digital Umm Al Quwain (services)	digitaluaq.ae
Umm Al Quwain	No standalone portal — data published via federal Bayanat	bayanat.ae

2.2 Federal Portal

Bayanat — The Official UAE Open Data Portal	FEDERAL
PORTAL	bayanat.ae
RUN BY	Federal Competitiveness and Statistics Centre (FCSC)
OVERVIEW	The central, whole-of-government portal and the single largest source of open data in the country. It consolidates thousands of datasets from federal ministries and authorities, and many emirate-level entities publish here too, so it is the best first stop for almost any challenge.
DATA THEMES	Economy, Health, Education, Environment, Food Security, Government, Infrastructure, Technology, Transport, Society.
HOW TO USE IT	Search by topic or publishing entity → download datasets directly in CSV, JSON or XML. Every dataset page shows its publisher, last-updated date, and usage metrics.
FOR DEVELOPERS	A functional REST API returns data programmatically (Python / JavaScript / cURL). Each resource is called by its Resource GUID, e.g. bayanat.ae/api/DatasetResources/GetDatasetResource?resourceID={GUID}.
BEST FOR	**Any theme — especially national-scale problems, cross-emirate comparisons, and challenges needing official statistics.**

2.3 Emirate Portals

Abu Dhabi — Abu Dhabi Open Data Platform	ABU DHABI
PORTAL	data.abudhabi/opendata/dataset
RUN BY	Abu Dhabi Digital Authority (ADDA)
OVERVIEW	Abu Dhabi's official open data platform, implementing the emirate's Government Data Management Policy. Datasets are drawn largely from the Statistics Centre – Abu Dhabi (SCAD) and local entities.
DATA THEMES	Economy, agriculture, geospatial mapping, environment, social statistics, government service indicators (e.g. TAMM).
HOW TO USE IT	Preview datasets as tables or download them, and explore geospatial layers on interactive maps. Open API endpoints are provided on individual dataset pages.
BEST FOR	**Abu Dhabi-specific service, economic, or geospatial challenges.**

Dubai — Data.Dubai

DUBAI

PORTAL	data.dubai/en
RUN BY	Digital Dubai Authority
OVERVIEW	Dubai's central open data platform, hosting the city's most valuable datasets in one unified catalogue organised by government entity (RTA, Dubai Land Department, DHA, Dubai Municipality, DED and others) and by theme.
DATA THEMES	Transport, property & real estate, economy, demographics, land use, city data.
HOW TO USE IT	Visual catalogue with maps and charts; export in CSV, KML (geospatial) and JSON. Some datasets are "open" and free; others are shared/commercial.
FOR DEVELOPERS	Integrated API for continuous data pulls; requires generating an API key & secret (OAuth token) via the developer documentation.
BEST FOR	**Dubai mobility, real-estate, and smart-city challenges.**

Sharjah — DSCD and Digital Sharjah

SHARJAH

OVERVIEW	Sharjah does not run a single unified open-data domain. Official statistics are centralised through the DSCD, while service-level data sits on Digital Sharjah — much standardised data is also contributed to federal Bayanat.

1) Department of Statistics & Community Development (DSCD) — dscd.ae

OVERVIEW	Sharjah's official statistics authority: census and socio-economic data for the emirate. Home of the Sharjah Census 2022/2023, household income & expenditure surveys, and annual statistical yearbooks.
DATA THEMES	Demographics, labour market, education, health, economy, housing, environment.
HOW TO USE IT	Browse interactive dashboards, tables and maps; export as Excel, CSV or PDF. Researchers can request granular microdata.

2) Digital Sharjah — ds.sharjah.ae

OVERVIEW	The emirate's unified government services platform (web + app, via UAE Pass). Less a dataset-download portal than a source of city service indicators across business, transport, utilities, social services, real estate, security and general government.
BEST FOR	**Sharjah demographic and community challenges (DSCD) | service-delivery context (Digital Sharjah).**

Ajman — Ajman Data

AJMAN

PORTAL	data.ajman.ae
RUN BY	Department of Digital Ajman
OVERVIEW	A modern open-data portal (Opendatasoft) covering datasets from Ajman government entities, with built-in AI tools for exploring data. One of the most developer-friendly portals in the country.
DATA THEMES	Business & industry, economics & finance, education, environment, health, housing, leisure & culture, public order, transport.
HOW TO USE IT	Build visualisations directly in the browser without downloading, or download files for offline use.
FOR DEVELOPERS	RESTful Explore API (v2) and GraphQL, with ready-made copy-paste snippets (cURL / Python / JavaScript) on every dataset — e.g. api.ajman.ae/v2.1/datasets.
BEST FOR	**Ajman business, licensing, and economic challenges.**

Ras Al Khaimah — RAK Centre for Statistics & Studies (RAKCSS)

RAS AL KHAIMAH

PORTAL	css.rak.ae
RUN BY	RAK Centre for Statistics & Studies
OVERVIEW	The sole official source of statistics for Ras Al Khaimah. It publishes statistical reports, indicators and dashboards, and operates the RAK Surveys Platform.
DATA THEMES	Population & demographics, labour, economy & trade, social and environmental indicators.
HOW TO USE IT	Browse indicators and dashboards, download statistical publications (PDF/Excel). Additional RAK data via Bayanat.
BEST FOR	**RAK-specific demographic, economic and trade challenges.**

Fujairah — Fujairah Government Open Data

FUJAIRAH

PORTAL	fujairah.ae/en/Pages/fujairahdata.aspx
RUN BY	Government of Fujairah (with the Fujairah Statistics Center: fscfuj.gov.ae)
OVERVIEW	The emirate's open-data page, consolidating resources from local entities such as the Fujairah Statistics Center, Police and Public Works. Functions mainly as a straightforward repository organised by government entity.
DATA THEMES	Municipal services, free-zone licensing, public works (e.g. road-network phases), demographic statistics.
HOW TO USE IT	Navigate by entity and download reports, statistical sheets and tables in PDF, Excel and CSV.
BEST FOR	**Fujairah municipal, infrastructure and demographic challenges.**

Umm Al Quwain — via Bayanat	UMM AL QUWAIN
OVERVIEW	Umm Al Quwain does not run a dedicated open-data (dataset-download) portal. Its unified government services gateway is Digital Umm Al Quwain, while downloadable datasets come through federal Bayanat.
1) Digital Umm Al Quwain — digitaluaq.ae	
OVERVIEW	Run by the Digital Government Department, Umm Al Quwain (formerly Smart UAQ). The emirate's unified government services portal and app — residents, businesses and visitors submit requests, track status, pay fees, and follow local news. Like Digital Sharjah, it is a service-delivery gateway rather than a dataset-download portal, useful for understanding UAQ services and processes.
2) Open datasets via Bayanat — bayanat.ae	
OVERVIEW	UAQ figures are published through the federal Bayanat portal and national statistical releases (FCSC). For UAQ challenges, filter Bayanat by the Umm Al Quwain region/entity.
BEST FOR	**UAQ service-process context (Digital Umm Al Quwain) | UAQ datasets: search Bayanat for UAQ-tagged data.**

2.4 Using Open Data in Your Submission

GOOD PRACTICE

- **Cite the exact dataset and its source portal** — this directly strengthens the Data Readiness and Problem Clarity criteria.
- **Prefer CSV/JSON and API access** if you plan to build a working prototype; PDF-only sources are fine for framing the problem but harder to build on.
- **Building a working prototype?** The most developer-friendly portals are **Ajman Data** (ready-made cURL / Python / JavaScript snippets and GraphQL), **Bayanat**, and **Dubai Pulse** — all offer programmatic API access.
- **Note the last-updated date and coverage** (which years, which emirate) so reviewers can judge feasibility.
- If a portal only offers restricted or aggregated data, most portals let you submit a **Data Request Form** for more specific records.
- **When in doubt, start on Bayanat:** it aggregates federal and much emirate-level data in one place.

COMPONENT 03

03

AI Tools

A starting toolkit to research, ideate, design, prototype, and pitch more efficiently.

BEYOND IDEAS · INTO IMPACT

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KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Every tool listed is accessible at **no cost**, through a free plan or a free trial.
- The list is **indicative, not exhaustive** — use any tools you prefer.
- Always **review AI output** and verify facts and data before relying on it.
- **Never paste** personal data, confidential government information, or unpublished datasets.
- **Export as you go** so you keep your work if a trial or credits run out.

This list is indicative, not exhaustive. You are free to use any tools you prefer. Whatever you use, always review AI output before relying on it, verify facts and data, and don't paste confidential or personal information into third-party tools.

3.1 Toolkit at a Glance

EXHIBIT 8 **Recommended free tools by category**

CATEGORY	TOOL	WEBSITE	FREE ACCESS
Research & AI Assistants	**ChatGPT**	chatgpt.com	Free plan
	Claude	claude.ai	Free plan
	Gemini	gemini.google.com	Free with Google account
	Perplexity	perplexity.ai	Free; no account needed
	Consensus	consensus.app	Free account
Ideation, Journey Mapping & Whiteboarding	**Miro**	miro.com	Free plan
	Smaply	smaply.com	Free plan
	Whimsical AI	whimsical.com/ai	Free plan
UI/UX Design, Wireframing & Prototyping	**Uizard**	uizard.io	Free plan
	Visily	visily.ai	Free plan
	Wireframe.cc	wireframe.cc	Free; no account needed
Presentations & Pitch Decks	**Gamma**	gamma.app	One-time free credits
	beautiful.ai	beautiful.ai	Free trial only
	Pitch	pitch.com	Free plan
Business Planning	**Venturekit**	venturekit.ai	Free tier
	IdeaBuddy	ideabuddy.com	Free plan + trial
Rapid App & Prototyping	**Lovable**	lovable.dev	Free plan (daily credits)
	v0	v0.dev	Free plan (monthly credits)

GENERAL TIPS

- Every tool below can be accessed at no cost, either through a permanent free plan or a free trial. Free plans change often — check the pricing page before you commit your workflow to a tool.
- Sign up with the same email across the team where possible, and share one workspace instead of creating separate accounts.
- Where a tool uses credits, plan the prompt before you send it. One well-specified request costs far less than five vague attempts.
- Export your work as you go (PDF, PPTX, images). If a trial ends or credits run out mid-hackathon, you still have your material.
- Never paste personal data, confidential government information, or unpublished datasets into these tools.

3.2 AI Across the HackArena Journey

Overview of AI usage in the hackathon journey:

EXHIBIT 9 **Suggested AI use by HackArena stage**

HACKARENA STAGE	TASK	SUGGESTED TOOL CATEGORY
Day 1 — Understand & Explore	Research the challenge, analyse relevant evidence, map user needs, and generate ideas.	AI assistants, research tools, collaborative whiteboards.
Day 2 — Build & Shape	Develop a visual concept, mock-up, prototype, or demonstration.	Wireframing, UI/UX design, and prototyping tools.
Day 3 — Refine & Pitch	Prepare and refine the presentation and supporting visuals.	Presentation and pitch-deck tools.

SUGGESTED AI TOOLS PER CATEGORY

3.3 Research & AI Assistants

ChatGPT

chatgpt.com

WHAT IT DOES	General AI assistant — brainstorm ideas, summarise research, draft content, and write or debug code.
FREE ACCESS	Free with a personal account, no payment details required. The free plan gives a capable model with daily usage limits that reset automatically.

Claude

claude.ai

WHAT IT DOES	AI research and reasoning assistant — analyse long documents, compare information, develop ideas, and support coding or structured research.
FREE ACCESS	Free account via email or Google sign-in. The free plan includes a usage allowance that refreshes through the day; longer documents and heavier sessions consume it faster.

Gemini

gemini.google.com

WHAT IT DOES	Google's AI assistant — research, analyse documents and images, and draft or summarise, with Google integration.
FREE ACCESS	Free with any personal Google account — if your team already uses Gmail or Drive, nothing extra to set up.
GETTING STARTED	1 Sign in at gemini.google.com with your Google account. 2 Type a question, or upload an image, screenshot, or document for analysis. 3 Use it alongside Google Docs and Slides to draft and tidy your submission. 4 Cross-check any statistics against an original source.

Perplexity

perplexity.ai

WHAT IT DOES	AI answer engine — fast, cited answers from live web sources; great for quick market and desk research.
FREE ACCESS	Free to use; basic searches run without an account. A free account saves history and gives a limited daily allowance of advanced modes.
GETTING STARTED	1 Open perplexity.ai and type a research question. 2 Read the answer, then open the numbered sources to confirm the claim. 3 Use follow-up questions to narrow scope. 4 Copy source links into your submission so judges can trace your evidence.

Consensus

consensus.app

WHAT IT DOES	AI search across 200M+ peer-reviewed papers — ground your problem statement and solution in real evidence.
FREE ACCESS	Free account gives unlimited paper searches, with a monthly allowance of AI-generated summaries and analysis.
GETTING STARTED	1 Sign up at consensus.app with email or Google. 2 Enter a yes/no or cause-and-effect question (e.g. "Does digital ID reduce service processing time?"). 3 Review the consensus meter and skim study summaries. 4 Cite two or three of the strongest papers in your problem statement.

3.4 Ideation, Journey Mapping & Whiteboarding

Miro

miro.com

WHAT IT DOES	Collaborative whiteboard — brainstorm, affinity-map, and diagram user journeys or system flows with your team.
FREE ACCESS	Free plan includes a small number of editable boards with unlimited collaborators — enough for one hackathon team. Use a single team board.
GETTING STARTED	1 Sign up at miro.com and create a free team workspace. 2 Open a board and pick a template (brainwriting, affinity diagram, or journey map). 3 Share the board link so everyone can add sticky notes at once. 4 Export the board as an image for your pitch deck.

Smaply

smaply.com

WHAT IT DOES	Customer journey mapping — build personas, stakeholder maps, and journeys to pinpoint the pain points behind your challenge.
FREE ACCESS	Free plan covers one personal workspace with a capped number of maps and personas — enough to map a single service journey end to end.
GETTING STARTED	1 Create a free account at smaply.com. 2 Build one persona for the affected user (resident, student, business owner). 3 Create a journey map with lanes for steps, channels, emotions, and pain points. 4 Highlight the worst 2–3 moments — that is where your solution should intervene. 5 Export the map for your presentation.

Whimsical AI

whimsical.com/ai

WHAT IT DOES	AI diagrams and mind maps — turn prompts into editable flowcharts, mind maps, user flows, and early wireframes.
FREE ACCESS	Free plan allows a limited number of boards per workspace, with a monthly allowance of AI generations.
GETTING STARTED	1 Sign up at whimsical.com. 2 Create a new flowchart, mind map, or wireframe. 3 Use the AI prompt for a first draft (e.g. "user flow for renewing a licence in three steps"). 4 Edit the generated nodes by hand — the draft is a starting point. 5 Share the view-only link with mentors for feedback.

3.5 UI/UX Design, Wireframing & Prototyping

Uizard

uizard.io

WHAT IT DOES	AI UI design — turn text prompts, sketches, or screenshots into wireframes and clickable mockups in minutes.
FREE ACCESS	Free plan supports a limited number of projects and screens — plan on one project for your prototype.
GETTING STARTED	1 Sign up at uizard.io. 2 Choose "generate with AI" and describe your app in a sentence or two, or upload a sketch. 3 Edit the generated screens — text, colours, components. 4 Link screens and hit preview for a clickable prototype. 5 Share the preview link in your pitch instead of static images.

Visily

visily.ai

WHAT IT DOES	AI UI design for non-designers — generate app/web wireframes and prototypes from text or a screenshot.
FREE ACCESS	Free plan aimed at individuals and small teams; covers wireframing and prototyping for a limited number of files.
GETTING STARTED	1 Create a free account at visily.ai. 2 Start from a text prompt, a screenshot of an existing service, or a template. 3 Drag and drop components to adjust the layout. 4 Add screen-to-screen links and switch to presentation mode. 5 Invite teammates by email to co-edit.

Wireframe.cc

wireframe.cc

WHAT IT DOES	Minimalist wireframing — sketch simple low-fidelity layouts to communicate an interface idea quickly.
FREE ACCESS	Free in the browser, no account needed. Free wireframes are shared via a public link, so keep sensitive content out of them.
GETTING STARTED	1 Open wireframe.cc — no sign-up required. 2 Drag on the canvas to draw boxes and pick the element type (button, image, text). 3 Label each element so the intent is obvious. 4 Copy the generated link or screenshot for your deck.

3.6 Presentations & Pitch Decks

Gamma

gamma.app

WHAT IT DOES	AI deck & one-pager generator — turn a prompt or outline into a polished, presentation-ready deck or page.
FREE ACCESS	One-time AI credit allocation at sign-up (roughly enough for several full decks plus edits). Free decks carry a small "Made with Gamma" logo; you can still export to PDF and PowerPoint.
GETTING STARTED	1 Sign up at gamma.app with Google or email. 2 Choose "Generate", then paste your pitch outline (a better input costs fewer credits). 3 Pick a theme and let it build the cards. 4 Edit text directly on the slides; regenerate sparingly. 5 Export to PDF or PPTX, or present from the browser.

beautiful.ai

beautiful.ai

WHAT IT DOES	AI presentation maker — build investor-ready pitch decks fast using smart, auto-formatting templates.
FREE ACCESS	No permanent free tier — access is through a free trial, so start it in the week you actually need to build the deck.
GETTING STARTED	1 Start the free trial at beautiful.ai. 2 Pick the pitch deck template. 3 Fill in the smart slides — layout adjusts automatically as you add content. 4 Export to PDF or PowerPoint before the trial ends so you keep a copy.

Pitch

pitch.com

WHAT IT DOES	Collaborative AI presentation workspace — generate and refine professional decks, improve slide messaging, and collaborate in real time.
FREE ACCESS	Free plan supports small teams with shared decks and real-time collaboration; advanced analytics and custom branding are paid.
GETTING STARTED	1 Sign up at pitch.com and create a workspace. 2 Start from a pitch template. 3 Invite teammates to edit different slides simultaneously. 4 Use presenter notes to split the speaking parts.

3.7 Business Planning

Venturekit

venturekit.ai

WHAT IT DOES	AI business plan generator — produce a business plan, financial forecast, market research, and pitch deck from your idea.
FREE ACCESS	A free tier covers plan generation with monthly limits; deeper customisation and export options are paid.
GETTING STARTED	1 Sign up at venturekit.ai. 2 Describe your idea, target customer, and market in the guided prompts. 3 Generate the plan, then review market sizing and financials critically — treat them as a first draft. 4 Pull the strongest sections (problem, market, revenue model) into your pitch deck.

IdeaBuddy

ideabuddy.com

WHAT IT DOES	AI venture-planning platform — develop the business model, estimate revenue and expenses, and convert an early idea into a structured plan.
FREE ACCESS	Free entry-level plan for one idea, plus a free trial of higher tiers if you need full financial modelling.
GETTING STARTED	1 Create an account at ideabuddy.com. 2 Start with the Idea Whiteboard to capture the concept in one view. 3 Move to the Business Model Canvas to define customers, channels, and revenue. 4 Use the financial section to sketch revenue and cost assumptions. 5 Export or screenshot the canvas for your submission.

3.8 Rapid App & Prototyping

Lovable

lovable.dev

WHAT IT DOES	AI full-stack application builder — turn a written description into a working web app or MVP, including interfaces and backend functionality.
FREE ACCESS	Permanent free plan with a small daily credit limit and a monthly ceiling — enough to build and demo a focused prototype if paced. Credits don't roll over, so don't burn them all at once.
GETTING STARTED	1 Sign up at lovable.dev with GitHub or Google. 2 Write one detailed prompt describing the app, its users, and main screens. 3 Use planning mode to think through a change before generating it. 4 Test the preview and fix one thing at a time. 5 Publish to the free hosted link and demo the live app in your pitch.

v0	v0.dev
WHAT IT DOES	AI web application and interface builder — generate working interfaces, full-stack web apps, and live prototypes from prompts.
FREE ACCESS	Free plan includes a small monthly credit allowance that resets each cycle — suited to a handful of screens rather than a full product.
GETTING STARTED	1 Sign in at v0.dev with GitHub or Vercel. 2 Prompt for one screen at a time (e.g. "dashboard showing service requests by status"). 3 Refine using the visual editor rather than regenerating. 4 Deploy with one click for a shareable link. 5 Download or sync the code to GitHub if a developer will extend it.

3.9 Responsible Use of AI and Data

RESPONSIBLE USE

- Use publicly available data and information that you are authorized to access.
- Do not upload personal information, confidential government documents, unpublished datasets, or restricted information to third-party AI platforms.
- Verify AI-generated facts, statistics, references, and technical recommendations against reliable sources.
- Clearly distinguish verified evidence from assumptions or AI-generated suggestions.
- Ensure that any AI-generated content, code, or visuals used in your solution are reviewed by the team before submission.

COMPONENT 04

04

Readiness Checklist

Your final gate before HackArena — tick every box before 26 Oct.

BEYOND IDEAS · INTO IMPACT

IN THIS SECTION

4.1 Pre-Event Readiness Actions..... 25

4.2 Logistics & Key Dates..... 25

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Complete all **six readiness actions** before 26 Oct.
- Bring your **laptop, charger and adapter**, plus any prototype resources.
- Read your **Challenge Profile** alongside this pack.

4.1 Pre-Event Readiness Actions

EXHIBIT 10 **Readiness checklist**

#	READINESS ACTION	DONE
01	Registered on hackathon.ae	☐
02	Selected an **available challenge** during registration on the platform	☐
03	Created a **team** on the platform as part of registration	☐
04	Attended the online Kickoff on **16 Oct** — or viewed the recording here: link	☐
05	Studied my selected **challenge profile** end to end	☐
06	Thoroughly studied this **Readiness Playbook**	☐

4.2 Logistics & Key Dates

EQUIPMENT TO BRING

Laptop, charger, adapter, and any prototype resources your solution needs.

KEY DATES

Kickoff 16 Oct · HackArena 26–28 Oct

SUBMISSION

Day 3 (28 Oct), 12:00 pm

ONE MORE THING

This Playbook is accompanied by the full **Challenge Profiles**, shared separately via drive. Read the profile for your chosen challenge alongside this pack — it's the single most important input to a strong, well-scoped solution.